

Temple of the Golden Pavilion

An exquisite, gold-coated Zen Buddhist temple in Japan's ancient imperial capital



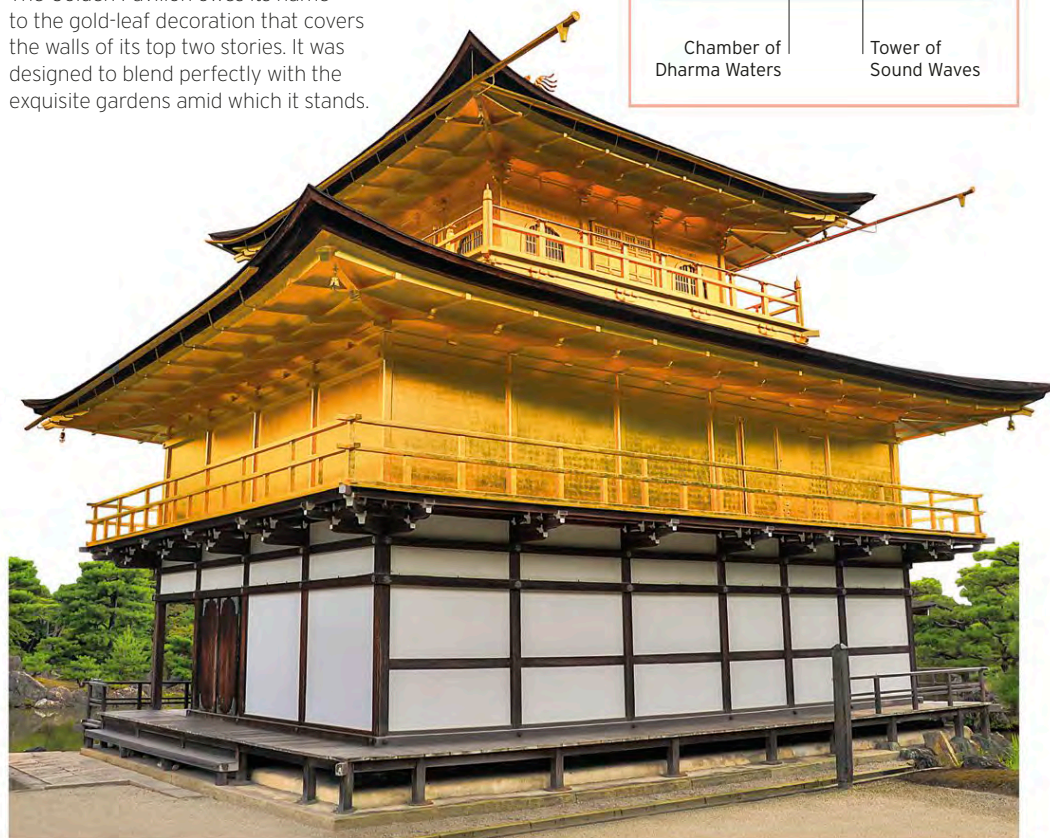
Reflected in the waters of the Mirror Pond (Kyōko-chi), the Golden Pavilion (Kinkaku-ji) is one of the most visited tourist sites in Kyoto. It was originally built as a private residence for Shogun Ashikaga Yoshimitsu (1358–1408), the most powerful man in Japan. He withdrew to the pavilion in 1398 after announcing his retirement from all official positions. On his death, as instructed in his will, the building was turned into a temple for Zen Buddhist monks.

Reconstructed treasure

Nothing of the original building has survived. In 1950, the temple was burned down by a 21-year-old monk—an event that formed the subject of a famous novel by Yukio Mishima, *The Temple of the Golden Pavilion* (1956). A new building has since been reconstructed, as close as possible to the original in every detail. The islands on the pond and the surrounding gardens, which form an essential part of the concept of the pavilion, are also scrupulously maintained.

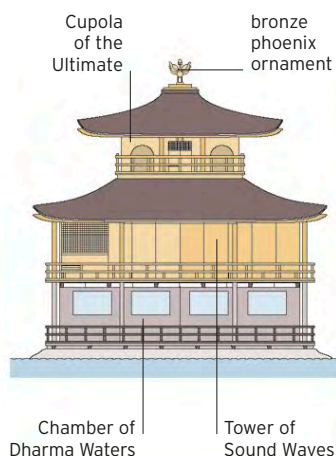
▽ GLOWING TEMPLE

The Golden Pavilion owes its name to the gold-leaf decoration that covers the walls of its top two stories. It was designed to blend perfectly with the exquisite gardens amid which it stands.



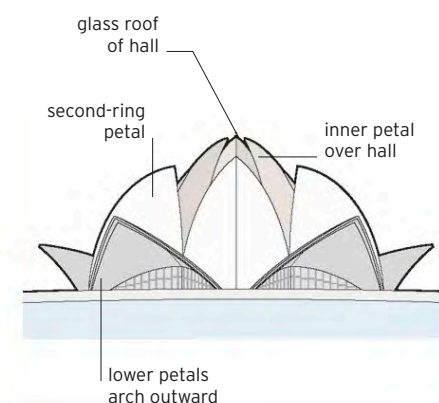
CONTRASTING STYLES

The pavilion's three floors are in different architectural styles. The ground floor, the Chamber of Dharma Waters, harks back to the classical simplicity of Japan's Heian era. The second floor, the Tower of Sound Waves, is in the style of a samurai palace. Only the top floor, the Cupola of the Ultimate, is distinctively Zen in architecture.



IMAGINATIVE STRUCTURE

The 27 external petals of the Lotus Temple are arranged in three concentric rings. The outer nine petals arch outward over each of the nine entrances. The second ring surrounds the outer hall, and the innermost nine petals enfold the prayer hall. The glass-and-steel roof of the domed interior floods the hall with natural light. The temple is about 112 ft (34 m) tall at its highest point. The marble-covered petals are supported by massive concrete ribs, which are visible inside the hall but not from outside.



△ GREEK MARBLE CLADDING

Cleaners work hard to keep the marble surface of one of the temple's petals pristine white. The stone, brought from Greece, is of the same kind as that used to build famous ancient Greek temples such as the Parthenon (see pp.98–99).

▷ PERFECT SYMMETRY

An aerial view of the Lotus Temple shows its rigorous geometry, with the nine surrounding ponds completing the effect. The tips of the inner ring of petals do not meet, leaving a space for natural light to penetrate the interior.